

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

AI Decisions at Work

A Professional Development Course for Managers and Team Leads

Your organization probably has AI tools already.

Do your people know how to use them well enough to trust the decisions they make with them?



🕒 COURSE DURATION: 60–75 MINUTES · 4 MODULES

What You Will Be Able to Do

- 1 Evaluate**
AI-assisted decision tools and assess their reliability, limitations, and appropriate use in your context.
- 2 Apply**
A governance framework to real workplace decisions involving AI-generated outputs and recommendations.
- 3 Defend**
A clear, evidence-based case for AI literacy and learning investment within your organization.



The Gap No One Talks About

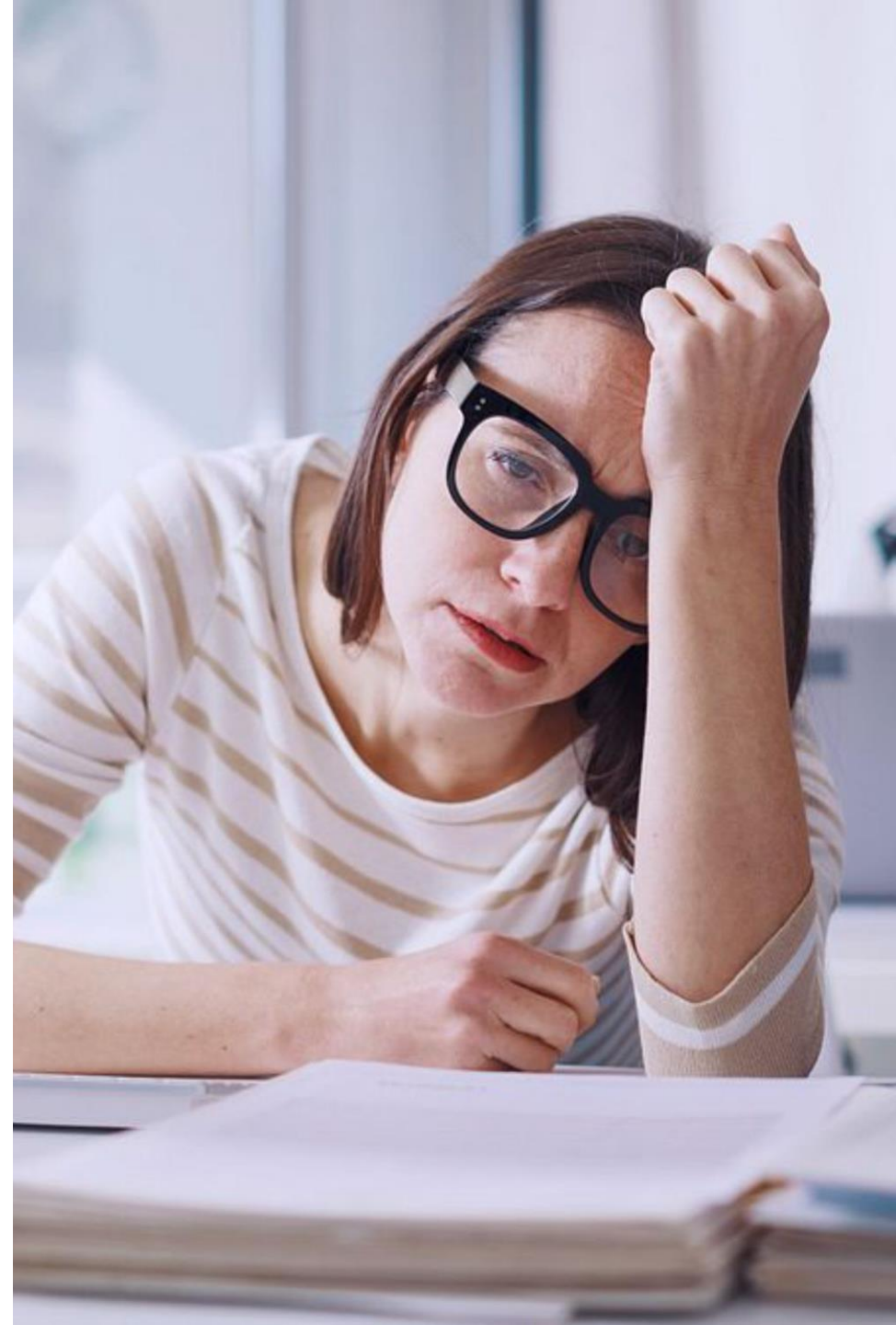
Organizations deploy AI tools and assume proficiency follows. It does not. The gap between access and reliable judgment is where decisions go wrong.

What Organizations Assume

Deploy AI tools → proficiency follows automatically.

What Actually Happens

The gap between access and reliable judgment is where decisions go wrong.



What Harvard Business School Found

HBS launched a required MBA course with a course-specific tutorbot and Julius.ai for natural-language analysis.

51%

Course-Bot Use

Reported engagement rate for the tutorbot.

100%

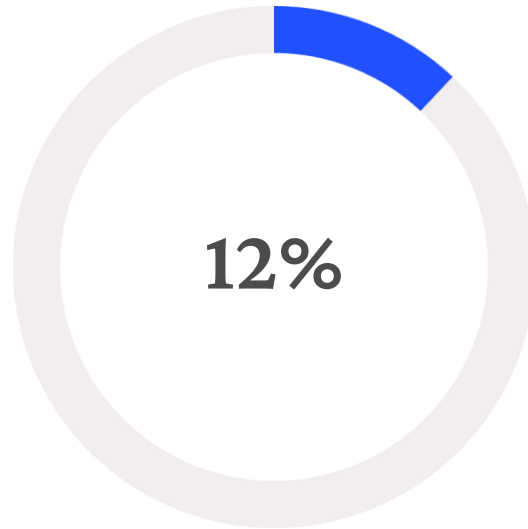
Julius.ai Use

Reported engagement rate for the analysis tool.

⚠ These are engagement numbers — not evidence that decisions improved.

The Uneven Adoption Finding

In a separate HBS accounting course, only about 12% of learners became frequent tutor users. Prompting uncertainty, policy gaps, and accuracy concerns persisted. Faculty observed better exam preparation — but observation is not causal proof.



Frequent Tutor Users

Share of learners who became regular users

Listen: [ADD AUDIO LINK]



What Good AI Learning Requires

Access alone does not produce proficiency. Four things do:



Practiced Decisions

Practicing decisions with AI in realistic work contexts



Grounded Tutoring

Tutoring grounded in approved, verified content



Applied Assessment

Assessment through applied projects, not multiple choice



Manager Support

Faculty or manager support that makes adoption repeatable



DISCUSSION ACTIVITY

Ground This in Your Own Context

Reflect

Think of one AI tool your organization currently provides.

Assess

How was it introduced — with structured practice, or simply made available?

Discuss

Ask your instructor to open a brief spoken discussion and work through what that introduction did and did not include.



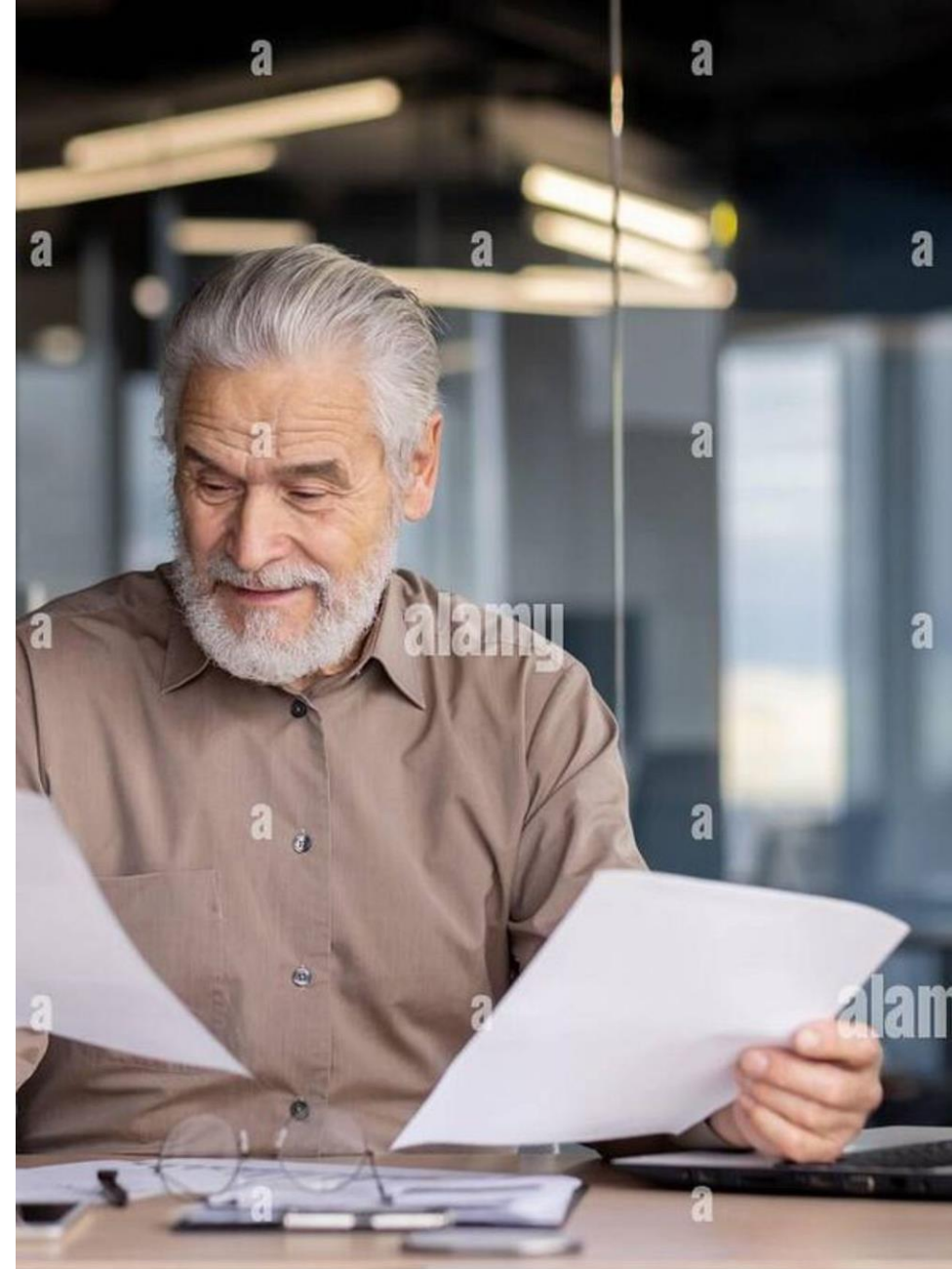
Not Every Decision Belongs in an AI Workflow

AI Adds Reliable Value

Where work is information-dense, repeatable, and reviewable — with clear inputs, verifiable outputs, and tolerance for occasional error.

Human Judgment Required

Where accountability, privacy, or reputational risk is real.



DECISION FRAMEWORK

A Three-Part Filter

Before using AI on any decision, ask three questions.

1 Verifiability

Can I verify the output before I act on it?

2 Accountability

Who is accountable if the output is wrong?

3 Data Appropriateness

Is the data involved appropriate to share with this tool?



Accuracy Is an Operational Problem

Even well-designed institutional deployments — including HBS programs — identified accuracy as an unresolved friction point.

The goal is not to avoid AI.

The goal is to match the tool to the decision type with honest criteria.

The Wrong Goal

Avoid AI entirely because of accuracy concerns.

The Right Goal

Match the tool to the decision type with honest, explicit criteria.



Sort Your Own Decisions

Bring two or three decisions you face regularly at work.

01

Bring

Two or three decisions you face regularly at work.

02

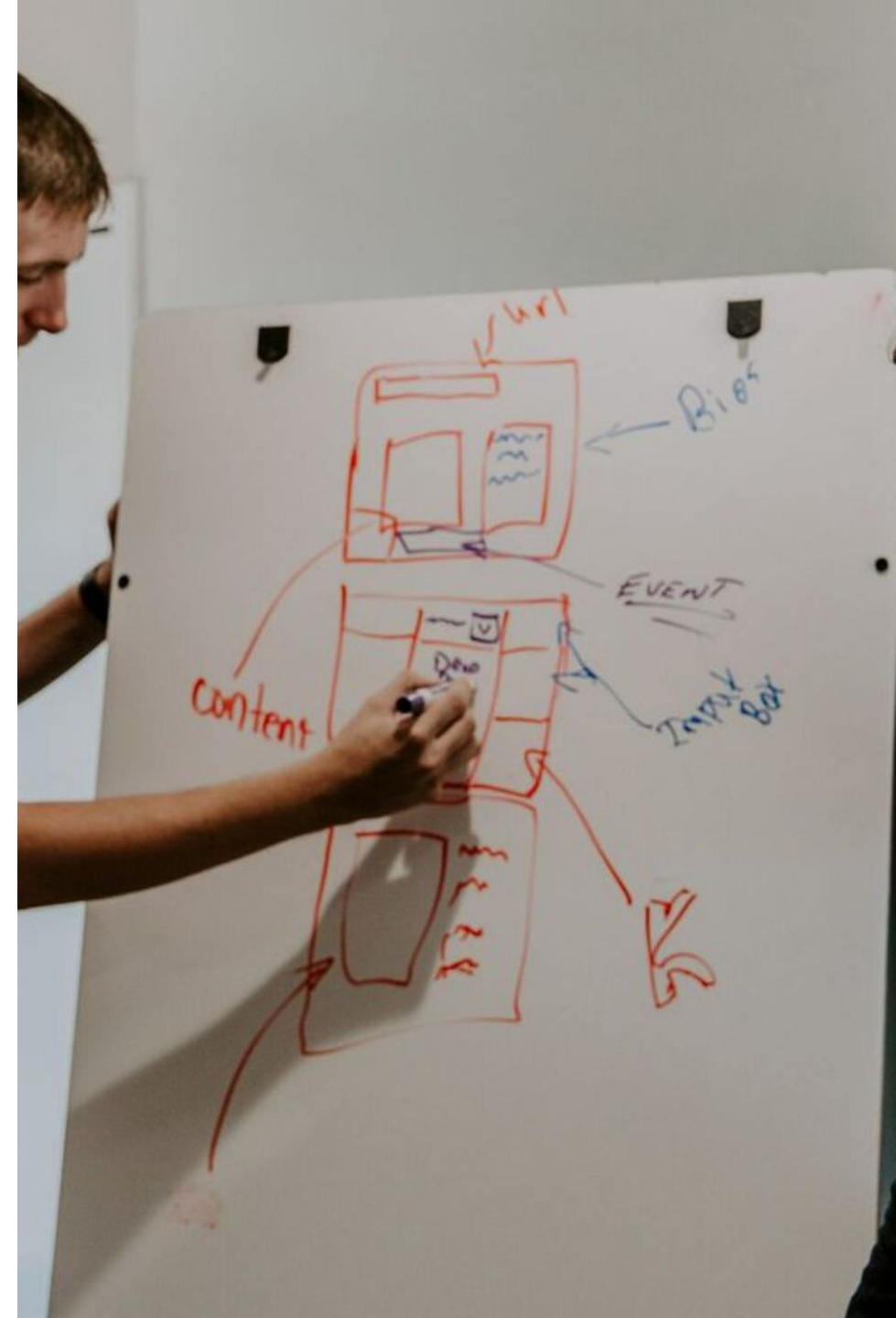
Evaluate

Apply the three-part filter: verifiability, accountability, and data appropriateness.

03

Classify

Your instructor will flag which belong in AI-assisted workflows and which require human oversight.



Four Governance Questions Every Manager Must Answer

1 Data Ownership

Who owns the data being used?

2 Accountability

Who is accountable if the output is wrong?

3 Compliance

Does the tool meet privacy and accessibility requirements?

4 Escalation Authority

Who has authority to override or escalate?

❏ If you cannot answer all four questions, the decision is not ready for an AI-assisted workflow.



LEGAL & COMPLIANCE

IP and Content Rights Are Operational Constraints

Harvard Business Publishing requires prior written permission and disabled data sharing before any catalog content is used in a generative AI tool.

⚠ This kind of constraint must be resolved before deployment — not discovered after.



The Escalation Framework

Three positions, clearly defined.



Act

Act on the output when it is verifiable and low-risk.



Verify

Verify before acting when stakes are moderate or accuracy is uncertain.



Refer

Refer upward when accountability, privacy, or risk exceeds your authority.



Unclear Governance Produces Avoidance

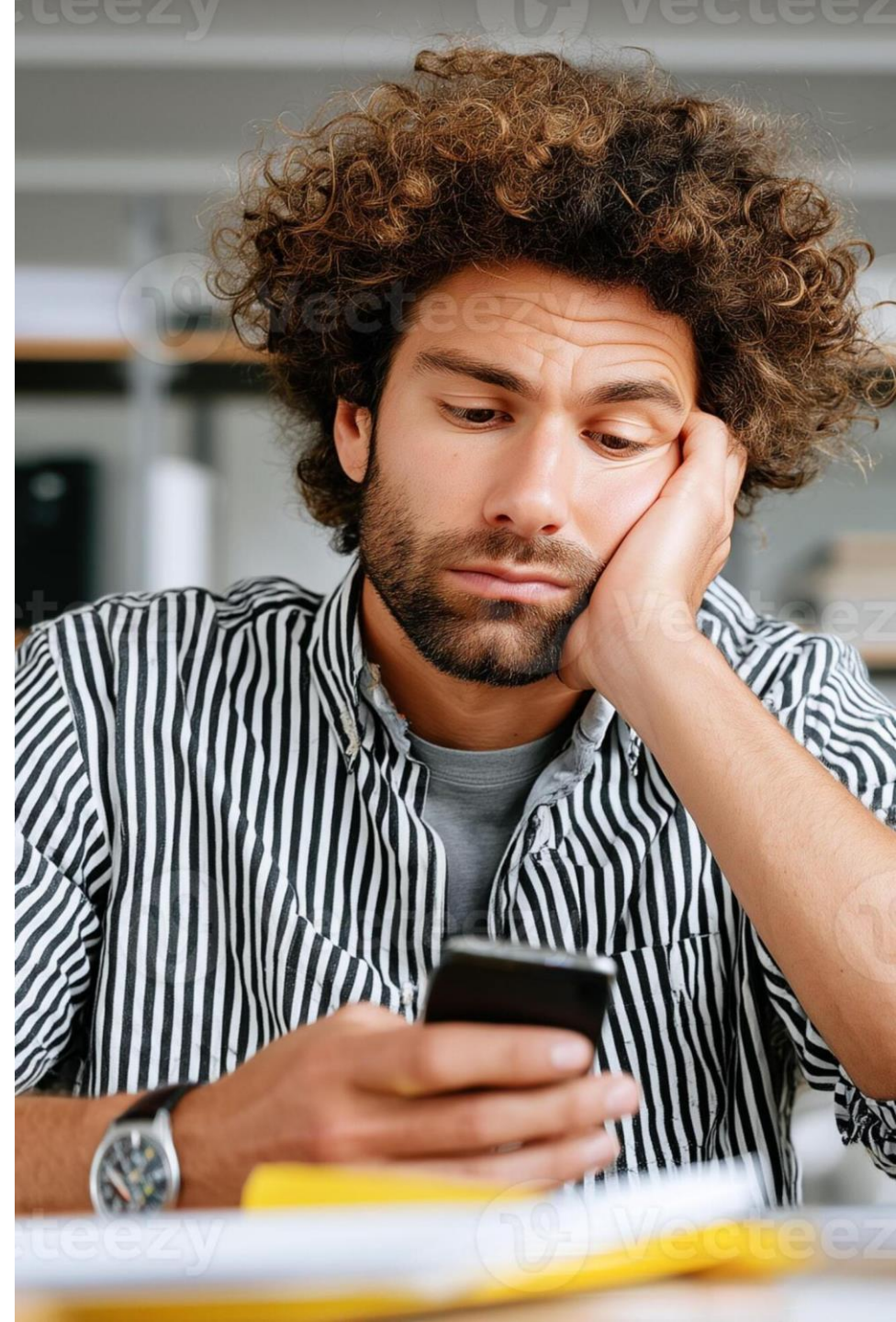
When policies are unclear, people default to caution — or stop using the tool entirely.

The Evidence

The 12% frequent-user finding at HBS partly reflects this dynamic.

The Principle

Governance is not a compliance checkbox. It is the foundation that makes AI adoption trustworthy.



Apply the Framework to a Real Situation

Think of a time an AI tool produced output you were unsure whether to act on.

01

Recall

Think of a time an AI tool produced output you were unsure whether to act on.

03

Identify

Your instructor will identify which governance question the situation turns on.

02

Apply

Ask your instructor to walk through that situation using the three-position escalation framework.



The First Evaluation Question

Is this program built around real decisions — or is it a technology demonstration in disguise?

Programs that lead with tool features rather than learner outcomes are a warning sign.

Warning Sign

Programs that lead with tool features rather than learner outcomes.

The Right Standard

Programs built around real decisions and observable learner outcomes.



Four Things to Require Before Approving Any Program

1 Defined Outcomes

Defined learner outcomes stated as observable behaviors.

2 Measurement Plan

A measurement plan for decisions before and after instruction.

3 Named Accountability

Named faculty or subject-matter expert accountability.

4 Support Terms

Defined support terms for the life of the program.

⚠ If any of these four are missing, the program is not ready for approval.



Engagement Data Is Not Learning Evidence

Completion rates, login counts, and tool usage figures tell you people showed up. They do not tell you decisions improved.

Engagement Data

51% course-bot use and **100%** Julius.ai use — the HBS figures tell you people accessed the tools.

Learning Evidence

Proof of behavior change requires pre/post measurement of decision quality under defined conditions — not usage logs.



What Real Measurement Requires

Targets set before the program launches, not after. Observational improvements reported by faculty do not establish causal effects without controlled comparison.

What is the evidence base?

Ask vendors to name the studies or data that support their claims.

Who measured it?

Independent measurement is more credible than vendor-reported outcomes.

Under what conditions?

Context matters — results from one institution do not automatically transfer to yours.

What was the comparison?

Without a control or baseline, improvement claims are unverifiable.



Success Metrics for a Professional Program

Decision Quality Improvement

Measured change in the quality of decisions made after instruction.

Completion Rate

Proportion of enrolled learners who finish the program.

Learner Use Patterns Over Time

Whether adoption sustained or declined after initial exposure.

Verified Behavior Change

Observable shifts in how learners approach AI-assisted tasks.

Faculty Workload Impact

Whether AI tools reduced or increased instructor burden.

The strongest programs report honestly on what worked and what did not — and use that evidence to improve.



VIDEO RESOURCE

Engagement vs. Outcomes — The Contrast

Watch: [ADD VIDEO LINK]

Engagement Metrics

Completion rates, login counts, and tool usage figures. These tell you people showed up.

Outcome Evidence

Pre/post decision quality measurement under defined conditions. This tells you learning occurred.



INSTRUCTOR-LED ACTIVITY

Evaluate a Program From Your Own Organization

Describe a proposed or existing AI learning initiative — or ask your instructor to present a realistic scenario.

→ **Work Through the Four Criteria**

Evaluate verbally: outcomes, measurement plan, accountability, and support terms.

→ **Identify the Gaps**

Ask your instructor to identify gaps and tell you what you would require before approving.



SELF-CHECK

Optional Self-Check

A private knowledge check on the four evaluation criteria and the escalation framework is available now.

What It Covers

The four evaluation criteria: defined outcomes, measurement plan, named accountability, and support terms. The three-position escalation framework: Act, Verify, and Refer.

How It Works

Nothing is recorded. It is a self-check, not an assessment. Ask your instructor how to begin.



What to Do Next

01

Run the Three-Part Filter

Ask: Can I verify the output? Who is accountable? Is the data appropriate to share?

02

Answer the Four Governance Questions

Apply them to any AI workflow: data ownership, accountability, compliance, and override authority.

03

Require the Four Evaluation Criteria

Defined outcomes, a measurement plan, named accountability, and defined support terms.

Thank you for your time and attention.

